



Trade links between Persia and China

This cave fresco in Dunhuang, China, from c. 600 CE, shows Sogdian merchants (from eastern Persia) on the Silk Road between the Sassanid Empire and China.



Parthian coins of King Gotarzes II

The Parthians retained the use of Greek on their coins—these were minted in 49–51 BCE—despite a fading knowledge of Greek during their empire.

The Greek–Macedonian empire of the Seleucids (see pp.98–99 and BEFORE) incorporated most of the Asian conquests of Alexander (see pp.96–97), including all of Persia and Mesopotamia. This empire was almost as vast as its predecessor—the first Persian empire of the Achaemenids (see pp.92–93)—but by the 3rd century BCE it had started to crumble as its many subjects asserted their autonomy.

Emergence of the Parthians

In the ruins of the empire, a people called the Parthians saw an opening. Once nomads who had settled in the northeast of the old Persian Empire, the Parthians had gained independence from Seleucid rule by 238 BCE. With

spread west from India along Parthian trade routes. These contacts denied Roman traders access to routes to China and India, leading to battles with the Roman armies. Parthia's most famous victory was the battle of Carrhae (or Harran, southeast Turkey) in 53 BCE, when the Roman army was utterly destroyed. Constant fighting with the Romans and nomads may have weakened the Parthians. They left little written record, so historians rely on their art and architecture, and foreign texts to paint a picture of the period.

THE PARTHIAN SHOT A trick used by the Parthians that involved feigning a rapid retreat, only to turn around in the saddle to fire arrows at their pursuers.

Sassanid fortified settlement

Built high above the fertile Iranian plateau, Takht-e Solalman, or Solomon's Throne, was one of the holiest sites of the Sassanid Persians. It housed a Zoroastrian fire temple with an eternally burning flame.

fire altars were erected to Ormazd, or Ahura Mazda, god of light, truth, and life. Most Sassanid rulers, however, were tolerant of religions other than their own, and large populations of Jews and Christians inhabited the empire, especially in Mesopotamia.

In the early 7th century the Sassanids suffered a serious military defeat at the hands of the Byzantine Emperor Heraclius. From this point, the weakened empire lay at the mercy of Islamic forces invading from the south.

The Revival of Persia

Persia emerged from Greek rule under the control of the Parthian people. Parthian expansion coincided with that of the Roman Empire, and the two powers spent three centuries at loggerheads with each other. The Persians themselves regained control in 226 CE, founding the rich and opulent Sassanid dynasty.

BEFORE

The first Persian Empire, based in southwest Iran, was ruled by the Achaemenid dynasty from c. 520 BCE << 92–93. When Alexander the Great << 96–97 swept the empire away in 334–323 BCE, the lands were not ruled by Persians for another 500 years.

THE SELEUCID DYNASTY

Alexander's conquests were partitioned after his death. Mesopotamia, Persia, and the east fell to a dynasty of **Greek–Macedonian rulers** founded

by **Seleucus I << 98–99**, who had marched with Alexander's conquering army into Asia. Seleucus set up a new capital, **Seleucia**, on the Tigris River.

A GREEK–PERSIAN MIX

Greek and Persian cultures mixed << 98–99 in the territory ruled by Seleucus I and his **Persian wife**,

Apama. Alexander had dreamed of a Greek–Macedonian–Persian

empire with its component cultures taking strength from one another. He had encouraged **intermarriage** between his soldiers and locals.

AN EMPIRE LOST

The Seleucid empire weakened as the remote, **Central Asian Greek city states << 98–99** of **Bactria** (in modern Afghanistan) and other states farther west won independence. The empire retreated from India and Bactria c. 250 BCE.

expansion east, they took control of the silk routes from China and began strangling what was left of the Seleucid Empire itself. Under their king Mithridates I, Parthians overpowered Mesopotamia to control all lands from India to the Tigris River. Mithridates recognized the value of the Greek–Persian culture he was inheriting, so he allowed the defeated cities to retain their administrative systems, trading ties, and languages, while placing Parthian governors to oversee them.

Between Rome and China

The Romans defeated and annexed the Seleucid kingdom, thus becoming neighbors of the Parthians. So began an uneasy relationship that cast Parthia as the enemy of Rome for the next 300 years.

Parthians were well suited to frequent border skirmishes. In the north their frontiers were under constant threat from Steppe nomads (see pp.138–39), who they held at bay with a tactic of lightning cavalry strikes.

The Parthians had indirect contact with the Han Chinese, whose envoy Zhang Qian (see p.129) traveled to the west and returned with accounts of their empire. Buddhist ideas, meanwhile,

What is certain is that the Persians reemerged under Ardashir I of the Sassanid dynasty, who defeated the Parthians in 226 CE, restoring Persian rule until 640 CE.

The Persians back in power

From the Parthians, the Sassanids inherited control of land trade routes to the east. They also faced the Parthians' perennial problems of repelling nomads from the north and east and the Romans from the west. Ardashir's son, Shapur I, won a famous victory over the Romans at Edessa in 259 CE, capturing

the Roman Emperor Valerian. Despite this initial success, war with the Romans and their successors, the Byzantines (see pp.198–99), continued through four centuries of Sassanid rule.

The Sassanids built a rich civilization based largely on agriculture and trade. Government was far more centralized than under Parthian rule, with local officials appointed by the king responsible for the

building of roads and cities, which was paid for by central government.

Zoroastrianism, the traditional faith of the Persians, was elevated to the status of official state religion, and many new

AFTER

Persia was rapidly annexed by the Islamic conquerors, but Persian culture lived on in its art and literature.

DEFEAT BY THE ARABS

Arab Muslim armies 174–77 >> routed the Sassanids at the **Battle of Qadisiyya** in 637 CE, and Muslims took over the institutions of power.

SEAT OF LEARNING

By 762 CE the **Abbasid caliphate 175 >>** having moved its capital to Baghdad, near Babylon, had become the world's greatest **center of scholarship**. Scholars of all religions made contributions to law, medicine, astronomy, mats, and philosophy.

PERSIAN HERITAGE

Persia's imperial past was not forgotten. Miniatures were painted and **epic stories** collected about the glories of the Achaemenid, Parthian, and Sassanid empires. Ferdowsi's **Shahnameh**, or "**Epic of Kings**" (c. 1000 CE), is a key work from this time.

MONGOL CONQUEST

In 1258, the **Mongols 166–67 >>** destroyed the art and learning of centuries, although their Islamic successors sought to repair the damage.



Sassanid plate

This gold plate, typical of Persian artistic refinement, shows the king hunting on a camel—an image found on many Sassanid artifacts.



PERSIAN QUR'AN